

Choosing Fonts and Icons for a Website

A working note for typography and iconography decisions, in order

Fonts and icons are functional systems, not decoration — they carry legibility, hierarchy, and meaning across every screen. Decide them the same way as color: start from constraints and function, narrow with association and testing, and validate before locking anything in.

Part 1 — Fonts

1. Start from technical constraints, not taste

- **Performance budget** — custom webfonts add load time and network requests. If the site targets low-bandwidth or 3G users, system fonts (already installed on the device) load instantly with zero extra requests.
- **Script support** — if the site needs a non-Latin script (Sinhala, Tamil, Arabic, etc.) alongside Latin, the chosen font stack must render both correctly, including ligatures and conjunct forms where relevant — not every font that looks fine in English handles other scripts well.
- **Licensing** — confirm the font is free for commercial/web use before committing; many attractive fonts are personal-use only.
- **Buildless or no-toolchain constraints** — if the project can't rely on a bundler or font-loading pipeline, system font stacks avoid the problem entirely.

2. Choose by pairing a system font stack

A system font stack tells the browser to use whatever high-quality font is already installed on the user's device, falling back gracefully across platforms. A practical multi-script stack looks like this:

```
font-family: -apple-system, "Segoe UI", Roboto, "Noto Sans", "Noto Sans Sinhala", sans-serif;
```

This resolves to San Francisco on iOS/macOS, Segoe UI on Windows, Roboto on Android — each already optimized for that platform — with Noto Sans Sinhala as an explicit fallback so the secondary script never silently breaks on a device that lacks native support.

3. Apply core typography theory

Beyond picking a typeface, a handful of long-standing typographic principles determine whether text actually reads well. These apply regardless of which font is chosen.

Principle	Rule of thumb
Hierarchy	Signal importance with at least two of: size, weight, color, spacing together — color alone is not enough
Contrast (size/weight)	Pair clearly large/bold headings with clearly smaller/regular body text; avoid mid-range sizes to avoid confusion
Line length (measure)	Aim for 45–75 characters per line for body text — shorter feels choppy, longer tires the eye before reaching the end

Line height (leading)	Body text: 1.4–1.6× the font size. Large headings: tighter, around 1.1–1.3×, since long lines a
Letter spacing (tracking)	Default or slightly negative tracking for large headlines; 0 to slightly positive for small caps/lab
Alignment	Left-align (or right for right-to-left scripts) for anything longer than a line or two; justify only with
Case	Avoid setting long text in all caps — it removes the word-shape cues readers rely on. Reserve
Widows and orphans	Avoid a single short word left alone on the last line of a paragraph or heading wrap — adjust v

Pairing multiple typefaces

Limit any project to two type families at most. When pairing, contrast in style rather than picking two fonts that look nearly identical — a geometric sans headline against a humanist serif body reads as intentional; two similar sans-serifs just look like a mistake. For a system-font-only project (as recommended above), this pairing decision often disappears — achieve hierarchy through weight and size variation within one font stack instead of introducing a second family.

4. Establish a small type scale, not a font zoo

Role	Typical size	Weight
Page title / H1	22–28px	500–600
Section heading / H2	18–20px	500
Body text	15–16px	400
Secondary / caption text	12–13px	400
Buttons / labels	14–15px	500

Two weights is usually enough (regular + medium/semibold). More weights add load time for custom fonts and rarely add real hierarchy value — spacing and size do more work than an extra font weight.

5. Test legibility in the real conditions

- Render actual content — not lorem ipsum — in every script the site supports, at the smallest size used in the UI.
- Check on an actual low-end phone screen, not just a design tool preview — rendering quality varies by device and OS font-hinting.
- Confirm line-height and spacing work for the script with the tallest ascenders/descenders or most complex conjuncts — tight spacing tuned for Latin text often clips non-Latin scripts.
- Check contrast of the chosen text color against the background at the actual font weight used for body copy (see the color guide for contrast ratios).

Part 2 — Icons

1. Pick one icon style and stay inside it

Mixing icon styles — some outlined, some filled, some from different libraries with different stroke weights — is one of the fastest ways to make a site feel unpolished. Choose one family and use it everywhere:

Style	Feel	Good fit for
Outlined / line	Light, modern, neutral	Utility UI, navigation, settings, most SaaS-style products
Filled / solid	Bold, confident, high-contrast	Primary actions, active/selected states, dense mobile UI
Rounded / duotone	Friendly, approachable, playful	Consumer, gamified, or younger-skewing audiences
Hand-drawn / illustrative	Warm, distinctive, high personality	Mascots, empty states, celebration moments — sparingly, not for

2. Match icon style to the visual identity, not the other way around

If the brand direction is playful and gamified, a strictly minimal outline icon set will feel mismatched next to a rounded, colorful mascot — and vice versa: hand-illustrated icons everywhere will feel cluttered next to a clean, restrained editorial layout. Pick the icon style after the creative direction and palette are locked, not before.

3. Use icons to support meaning, never to replace a label alone

- Pair every functional icon with a text label, or at minimum an accessible label (aria-label) — icon meaning is not universal and varies by culture and familiarity.
- Keep icon meaning consistent across the whole product — the same icon should never mean two different things on two different screens.
- Reserve color-coded icons (e.g. green check, red X) for cases where color isn't the only cue — shape and position should also communicate the meaning for color-blind users.

4. Set sizing and touch-target rules once

Use case	Icon size	Touch target
Inline with body text	16–18px	n/a
Navigation / toolbar	20–24px	44×44px minimum
Standalone action button	24px	44×44px minimum
Decorative / illustrative	32px+	n/a (not interactive)

The 44×44px minimum touch target follows common mobile accessibility guidance (matches WCAG 2.1 target-size guidance) — the icon itself can be smaller, but the tappable area around it should not.

5. Decide licensing before adoption, not after

Icon libraries range from fully free (Tabler Icons, Feather, Lucide, Material Symbols) to attribution-required or paid (some Font Awesome sets, premium packs). Confirm the license covers commercial use and doesn't require per-icon attribution before building the icon set into the product — swapping an entire icon

library late in a project costs real rework.

Quick summary — fonts: constraints first (performance, script support, licensing) → system font stack with explicit script fallback → apply hierarchy, contrast, line-length, leading, tracking, alignment, and case rules → small type scale, two weights → test with real content on real devices. Icons: pick one style → match it to the locked creative direction → pair with labels, keep meaning consistent → fix sizing and touch targets → confirm licensing before adopting.